



^ GALAPAGOS FINCHES

On his voyages, Darwin collected many different specimens of Galapagos finches which he believed may have descended from a common ancestor.

DARWIN AND WALLACE

In the mid 19th century, British naturalists Charles Darwin and Alfred Russel Wallace independently came up with the theory of evolution by natural selection. They both had experience of fieldwork in the tropics – an environment boasting high biodiversity, competition for resources, and marked differences in the organisms living in separate areas. They both wondered how and why such natural phenomena had arisen. On his travels Wallace collected specimens for study and sale, and it was in the Malay Archipelago that he formulated

his explanations for the geographical distribution of organisms – biogeography – and realized the role of natural selection in evolution. Meanwhile, Darwin's five-year voyage on *HMS Beagle* around the southern hemisphere as a gentleman naturalist provided him with much material to formulate his own theory of evolution. In 1858, Wallace and Darwin produced a joint publication on natural selection, and the following year Darwin expanded the theory to produce his famous and influential book, *On the Origin of Species*.



^ COLLECTION BOX

Both Darwin and Wallace were fascinated by insect diversity, especially as found in the tropics, and were keen collectors.

< BIOGEOGRAPHY

The distribution of certain reptile, therapsid, and plant fossils across the southern continents shows that they were once joined as a supercontinent, called Gondwana.

Mesosaurus
reptile fossils from
the Permian Period



^ EARLY BIRD

The discovery of the fossil *Archaeopteryx* in 1861 revealed characteristics that provided an evolutionary link between two major groups: reptiles and birds.

